

CONGO BASIN

The dark green heart of Africa

The Congo Basin was carved by glaciers into a vast depression about the size of Europe. Much of the 78 in (2,000 mm) of rain that falls over the area each year ultimately drains into the Congo River, the second largest in the world. The river defines the character of the entire region, but it also represents an ecological barrier, with many groups of species found only on one side or the other—for example, chimpanzees live to the north of the river, while bonobos, or pygmy chimpanzees, occur only to the south.

Abundance under threat

Up to 10,000 plant species grow in the Congo Basin, about a third of which are found nowhere else. More than 1,000 bird species live here, as well as 700 known species of freshwater fish. New species of mammal are being discovered regularly in the basin, including fairly large animals that had remained unknown until relatively recently. The okapi was first described in 1901, followed by the bonobo in 1929, yet the forest elephant was not discovered until 2001.

In addition to its vast amounts of wildlife, the Congo Basin has been inhabited by humans for more than 20,000 years and is currently home to or supports more than 75 million people. Although new flora and fauna species undoubtedly exist in large areas of rainforest that remain unexplored, as the human population continues to grow, many are likely to become extinct before discovery. This is due to exploitation of land for agriculture, mining, fossil fuels, logging, and hunting for the bushmeat trade.

The forest in the Congo Basin is **so dense**, only **1% of sunlight** reaches the ground



ADAPTABLE ANTELOPE

Sitatunga emerge from forests to graze in wet grasslands and swamps at night. Their long, splayed hooves and flexible foot joints allow them to walk on waterlogged ground without sinking. They are excellent swimmers and use the water to escape predators.

BONOBO

GUTS OF THE MATTER

Bonobos, or pygmy chimpanzees, are highly social, fruit-eating apes endangered by habitat loss and hunting. Threats to the entire ecosystem: the seeds of many tree species cannot germinate unless they pass through the apes' guts.

AFRICAN CHERRY

THE MEDICINE TREE

The African cherry grows widely in the Congo Basin's mountain forests. Its bark is used in African medicine to treat everything from chest pains to mental illness, and it shows promising cancer-fighting properties.

Contains the second-largest block of rainforest in the world

Home to around half of Africa's elephant population